Structure, Typology, and Motivation of the Incredulity Response Construction

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[**Structure**] The so-called Incredulity Response Construction (IRC, aka Mad Magazine Sentence, Akmajian 1984, Lambrecht 1990) conveys a speaker's surprise, incredulity or disagreement toward the previous speech. In structure, it is deprived of tense, resulting in the presumed default realization of a subject (*Me?*) and its predicate (*Worry?!*). Previous accounts fall short of providing motivation, simply ascribing such structural upheaval to incongruity or incompatibility between the two sentential components and subsequent iconic rendition in syntax. The current paper attempts to probe further for a principled motivation. It also has an empirical goal of extending the purview of construction to a quotative-origin construction in languages like Korean (and Japanese).

[**Typology**] A well-established type of IRC like (1) is termed here as Coordinative IRCs (CIRC), since a coordinative conjunction (sometimes tacitly, then, asyndetic subtype) intervenes between a subject and the predicate. First, two components are treated on par, as comparable to nominals from quotation (cf. Sadock 1969, Saka 1998). Second, IRC predicates are severed from their subjects through the loss of tense to become an independent entity. In contrast, Korean (and Japanese) has a special construction that bears a quotative marker at the end without an utterance verb and has similar interpretive effects as the CIRC (cf. Szcześniak 2018). Naturally situated in contexts (2), which are essentially the same in the order of *what*–IRC–coda as argued for the CIRC, this quotative construction, I argue, should be defined as another type of the IRC, hence Quotative IRCs (QIRC). First, since the erstwhile embedded clause is independently used as a main clause, this construction arises from insubordination (Evans 2007). Second, a speaker's emotional stance (of surprise) is often expressed by shared morphology (*-la-ko* or *–ta-ko*) in *what* and the IRC.

[**Analysis**] Both types of the IRC are alike in taking quotation or echo as a rule of formation, though different in the extent of explicitness. They crucially differ in the domain, at which a challenge is directed. First, the CIRC takes issue with a *proposition* by teasing apart a subject in Spec,*v*P from *v*P. Assuming Chomsky's (2008) proposal that phase is identified in terms of proposition, I argue that this operation of *decomposing vP* is a well-suited strategy to challenge a proposition. In contrast, the QIRC takes issue with *speech act*, the marker (a sentence final particle) of which is repeated and followed by a quotative marker *–ko* (3c. imperative *-la* > *-la-ko*, 3d. (ex)hortative *-ca* > *-ca-ko*) or determined by default for a purported speech act, 3a. declarative *-e* > *-ta-ko*, 3b. interrogative *-ni* > *-nya-ko*). The present analysis turns to Ross's (1970) implicit performative analysis, placing utterance verbs in translation of the IRC's (i.e., B's remarks) in (3), e.g., declarative 'I say that ~,' interrogative 'I ask if ~' and so forth. The *QIRC challenges* a *speech act*. In sum, both types of the IRC challenge what is expressed in phase, i.e., a proposition in *v*P or a speech act in CP.

[Implications] The proposed distinction has broader typological implications. It suggests that languages systematically recruit one of two independent grammatical resources to express incredulous responses: coordination, which externalizes the semantic incompatibility between subject and predicate, or quotation, which externalizes the speaker's distance from a previous speech act. This typology not only unifies a wide range of previously isolated constructions under a single discourse-functional category but also reveals that the expression of surprise follows two recurrent structural pathways across languages. The analysis therefore provides a principled account of how discourse structure, clause architecture, and speech-act representation interact in the grammatical encoding of incredulity, offering a new typological perspective on the interface between syntax, quotation, and expressive meaning.

(1) *Hvad?* (Danish) = *wh*-preface
what
Mig, lave mad? = IRC
I:ACC make:INF food
Jeg kan ikke engang lave røræg! = CODA
I:NOM can not even make:INF scrambled.eggs
'What? Me, cook?! I cannot even make scrambled eggs.' (Szcześniak 2018: 174, (9))

(2) Son: Apeci, ce ecey cha-lul sa-ss-e-yo. (Korean)
dad I yesterday car-ACC buy-PST-IND-POL
'Dad, I bought a car yesterday.'
Dad: *Mwue(-la-ko)?* = *wh*-preface
what-IND-QUOT
Cha-lul sa-ss-ta-ko?! = IRC
car-ACC buy-PST-IND-QUOT
Ne-ka ton-i eti iss-e?! = CODA
you-NOM money-NOM where exist-IND
'What (did you say)? (Did you say you) bought a car?! You don't have money for that!'

(3)a. A: Ecey pi-ka manhi o-ass-e
yesterday rain-NOM much come-PST-IND
'It rained a lot yesterday.'
B: Pi-ka manhi o-ass-ta-ko?!
rain-NOM much come-PST-IND-QUOT
'You, Say that it rained a lot (yesterday)?!'

b. A: Mina-ka yeyppu-ni?
Mina-NOM be.pretty-Q
'Is Mina pretty?'
B: Mina-ka yeyppu-nya-ko?!
Mina-NOM be.pretty-Q-QUOT
'You, Ask whether Mina is pretty?!'

c. A: Ese ca-la
soon sleep-IMP
'Go to sleep immediately.'
B: Ese ca-la-ko?!
soon sleep-IMP-QUOT
'You, Order that I go to sleep immediately?!'

d. A: Sanchayk ka-ca.
walk(-ACC) go-HORT
'Let's take a walk.'
Sanchayk ka-ca-ko?!
walk(-ACC) go-HORT-QUOT
'You, Suggest that we take a walk?!'

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